Extradition limits will curb US-Mexico security cooperation upside

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【メール原文】

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Extradition limits place ceiling on US-Mexico security cooperation

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As heightened US scrutiny of illicit financial flows complements President Claudia Sheinbaum's recent efforts to strengthen oversight by Mexican institutions, the tougher enforcement environment will deepen bilateral cooperation.
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However, Mexico's firm opposition to US troops on its soil and its resistance to extraditing politicians with alleged criminal ties will cap how far the security relationship can progress—and set up a growing flashpoint as President Donald Trump ramps up extradition demands ahead of the June 2027 Mexican elections.
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Meanwhile, persistent drug flows into the US will constrain the scope for broader gains against Trump's success metrics and sustain pressure on Mexico even after November's midterm elections in the US, despite expanded border coordination.

Scrutiny of criminal organizations' financial flows will improve bilateral cooperation. Recent US enforcement against anti-money laundering and sanctions violations marks the latest step by the Trump administration to disrupt criminal organizations' financial networks. The US will calibrate scrutiny to avoid excessive disruption to the financial system, but the broader push will probably raise compliance costs for institutions in both countries.

On 29 September, Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC), working with Mexico's Financial Intelligence Unit (UIF), sanctioned companies and individuals involved in money-laundering schemes. The Treasury also targeted a US bank with a $1.2 billion fine for failing to prevent money laundering. That coordination reflects closer information sharing between OFAC and the UIF. Mexican authorities now conduct more parallel financial investigations rather than simply responding to US designations or demands. Sheinbaum's effort to strengthen the UIF through broader interagency coordination is yielding results aimed at shielding Mexico's financial system from wider US intervention.

Bilateral operational cooperation will continue to evolve. The Sheinbaum administration has authorized more sophisticated joint training, including the entry of US Navy SEAL personnel for special forces training with Mexican forces. Sheinbaum still opposes the presence of regular US troops on the ground, but has expanded information sharing and military-to-military coordination through formal channels. Joint operations have increased drug seizures and arrests of criminal figures. Sheinbaum is betting that

these mechanisms will produce enough results to deter unilateral US action. US-Mexico relations have improved from a poor baseline in 2025, but 2026 has also been quite volatile as Trump continues to press Sheinbaum despite recent operational successes.

Cooperation is producing results, but these will fall short of Trump's goals. In October, Mexico deployed armed forces units, helicopters, drones, and anti-drone systems along the border in coordination with a US deployment that reinforced maritime and border surveillance. The mirror operation, in which Mexican and US forces operated simultaneously on both sides of the border, served Sheinbaum's goal of expanding cooperation while underscoring her defense of national sovereignty. While fentanyl flows (10,369 pounds of fentanyl seized in August 2026) have fallen sharply since 2025, the White House will continue pressing Mexico to drive them to zero, ensuring sustained pressure.

Moreover, the Trump administration continues to pressure Mexico to show more measurable progress against criminal groups. The US included Mexico on Trump's September 2026 Presidential Determination on Major Drug Transit or Major Illicit Drug Producing Countries, commonly known as the Majors List, while Trump and senior officials continue to demand additional results from Sheinbaum in public. Despite the confrontational rhetoric, Sheinbaum will stick to her current approach and sustain engagement to avoid further escalation.

Pressure over accused politicians will rise ahead of the Mexican midterms. Sheinbaum continues to protect politicians with alleged ties to criminal groups, including former Sinaloa governor Ruben Rocha, from the US justice system. She is trying to buy time, hoping that sustained operational results will reduce Trump's pressure on that front. Her administration also wants to preserve coalition unity, which could fray if Morena politicians begin to fear that cooperation with US authorities on extraditions could lead to a broader purge.

The period before Mexico's June 2027 midterm elections will prove especially difficult as the US government grows more frustrated with Sheinbaum's delays. Morena's veto of gubernatorial hopefuls over alleged criminal links will do little to ease US concerns about protection networks in several state governments. That dynamic will probably lead to more revelations about ongoing investigations and additional visa revocations for sitting officials. Regardless of the US midterm results, Trump will maintain a high-pressure approach as he revisits his Donroe Doctrine successes and focuses on Mexico to maintain border issues as a major voter concern in the second half of his administration.

Sovereignty concerns will remain a key limit on deeper cooperation. Sheinbaum will continue to reject arrangements that bypass the federal government, as shown by her recent criticism of the US-backed police academy in opposition-governed Queretaro. Her administration will try to keep cooperation concentrated in federal channels and prevent Washington from building independent security ties with Mexican states. The goal is to preserve control over information flows to US security agencies.

The US government's longer-term goal will be to secure on-the-ground security cooperation similar to arrangements in other Latin American countries. But that remains a red line for Sheinbaum and the Mexican armed forces. As a result, Mexico will try to deliver measurable security gains and expand coordinated operations, thereby limiting US incentives to act unilaterally. That balance will continue to test the bilateral relationship and, while it is unlikely to spill into a wider rupture that affects trade talks, it will remain a major concern for Sheinbaum. Still, progress on tariff relief and other United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement issues will probably continue as long as the US does not intervene

directly in Mexico or target former president Andres Manuel Lopez Obrador and his family.

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